

FRONTIER MODEL SLM BUYER PROFILE MEMO FOR ASHWIN

I. RECOMMENDED BUYER PROFILE SEQUENCE

The core GTM decision for the Frontier Model SLM is not which market is largest in the abstract. It is which buyer profile gives us the strongest starting environment for proving the product, improving the model, and building a repeatable path into larger markets.

On that question, the answer is clear: the product should start with closed-loop talent transformation and placement intermediaries.

That is not because they are the largest eventual market. They are not. Large employers are larger, and state systems may be more important as long-run infrastructure buyers. But those markets are slower, harder to operationalize, and less useful as initial proving grounds. The first market has a different job. It must help us demonstrate that the model improves strategic workforce planning in a way that is visible, commercially legible, and rich enough in outcomes data to make the system smarter over time.

Closed-loop intermediaries are the best fit for that job. They sit closest to a usable loop across talent assessment, pathway design, employer demand interpretation, deployment, and observable outcomes. In other words, they combine planning pain with operational control. That makes them the strongest environment for MVP proof and the fastest path to the kind of feedback that makes the model better.

This is also where staffing firms belong when they function as true workforce intermediaries rather than simple placement vendors. The key question is not whether a firm is labeled staffing. It is whether it meaningfully shapes talent supply, interprets employer demand, routes talent into roles, and observes enough downstream outcomes to create a learning loop for the model.

The representative target set in this lane supports the thesis. Revature emerged as the strongest single target, but the category does not depend on Revature alone. SkillStorm, Dev10, Wiley Edge, FDM Group, Multiverse, and others suggest this is a real lane, not a one-off account. The category appears deep enough to support a GTM motion rather than a single lighthouse deal. Commercially, it is also strong enough to matter. Rough likely ACVs are in the \$250K-\$750K range, with larger strategic accounts above that. Rough TAM is approximately \$50M-\$105M, which is exactly what a wedge market should look like: large enough to matter, small enough to be attackable, and structurally suited to proof.

The second market should be employer-connected mission and workforce intermediaries. This is not as strong a pure proof environment as the first lane, but it is the most important bridge market. It expands the story from a commercial workforce intermediary thesis into a broader workforce-system thesis. It brings in stronger employer-facing legitimacy, social mobility narratives, and pathway-design logic. In other words, it helps translate proof into a more expansive market story. Year Up / YUPRO and Per Scholas are the clearest targets here. This lane is not the best place to start, but it is likely the best place to go second.

The third market should be community college apprenticeship and pathway programs. This appears to be the strongest higher-ed-adjacent lane because it preserves occupational specificity, employer linkage, and repeatability better than generic higher education or even elite co-op institutions. If the first market proves the model and the second broadens the legitimacy frame, this third market begins the expansion into institutional pathway systems. Apprenticeship Carolina, NOVA, Ivy Tech, Wake Tech, and Trident are representative examples of the kind of targets that make this lane attractive.

The fourth market should be large employers with strategic workforce planning pain. This is likely the strongest direct commercial market in the full landscape. It offers the highest likely ACVs, the largest direct TAM, and in theory the richest KPI-level outcomes data. But it should not be the first market because those advantages come bundled with harder outcomes-data access, greater integration burden, slower proof cycles, and a higher

risk that early wins become bespoke rather than repeatable.

This is also where large staffing and talent-services firms belong when they are effectively operating as enterprise workforce planners, deployment engines, or managed talent platforms rather than as closed-loop training intermediaries. In those cases, the buyer behaves less like a classic intermediary and more like an enterprise workforce operator.

This is a scale market, not the cleanest first proof market. It will matter enormously once there is stronger evidence and a more mature product story.

The fifth market should be higher-ed institutions with co-op and externship outcome closure. This is a narrower but high-quality lane. Northeastern- and Drexel-type institutions are compelling because they solve some of higher ed's normal weakness around outcome closure. But the category appears more dependent on outliers and less obviously deep than community college pathways. It is valuable, but selective.

The sixth market should be state workforce agencies and systems. These are major infrastructure buyers and likely important long-run anchors. But they are too burdened by procurement complexity, governance drag, and slower proof cycles to be the first entry market. They should come after the model has already been proven in more operationally tractable environments.

The most important strategic point is that this sequence is not driven by TAM-first logic. It is driven by proof quality, data value, and compounding learning. The first market must help the product become smarter and more credible. The second market must help that proof become more legible to adjacent buyers. The third market must begin institutional expansion. Only then does it make sense to push into the largest and most complex direct markets.

This is also why the arithmetic model is useful but not sufficient on its own. Large employers score extremely well on raw attractiveness, and state systems score strongly on long-run strategic importance. But the sequencing logic still favors intermediary lanes because they do a better job of closing the proof loop early. Similarly, employer-connected workforce intermediaries are strategically more important than a raw score alone suggests because they serve as the strongest bridge market.

If we are choosing the starting lane for the Frontier Model SLM, the recommendation is straightforward:

1. Start with closed-loop talent transformation and placement intermediaries.
2. Move next into employer-connected mission and workforce intermediaries.
3. Expand into community college apprenticeship and pathway programs.
4. Scale into large employers.
5. Selectively pursue higher-ed institutions with co-op and externship closure.
6. Enter state workforce systems once the product and evidence base are more mature.

That is the order that best balances MVP proof, model improvement, market expansion, and long-run strategic control.

II. METHODOLOGY

The buyer-profile work was built to be auditable, adjustable, and strategically useful rather than impressionistic.

First, the work defined a consistent evaluation framework for every buyer profile. The criteria included:

- ? planning friction coefficient
- ? SLM solution fit
- ? solution upside potential
- ? economic buyer strength
- ? internal champion strength
- ? willingness to pay
- ? ability to pay

- ? sales cycle complexity
- ? integration burden
- ? data completeness potential
- ? outcomes data value
- ? outcomes data accessibility
- ? speed to proof
- ? strategic signaling value
- ? replicability
- ? GTM role value
- ? risk score

Second, the framework was turned into a scoring methodology rather than a qualitative checklist. A weighted model was used to balance:

- ? buyer need and SLM fit
- ? buying dynamics
- ? data and learning value
- ? strategic expansion value
- ? risk

Third, the process explicitly separated prospecting-stage logic from more informed strategic judgment. A public-information first pass was run so the reasoning could be audited without relying on internal context. A separate insider-adjusted second pass then tested whether direct strategic knowledge materially changed the sequencing.

Fourth, the work moved from buyer-profile theory to target-account reality. Representative target organizations were identified and scored within each buyer type. This helped answer several questions that profile-level reasoning alone could not answer:

- ? Is the category actually deep, or is it being propped up by one or two strong names?
- ? Does the category have enough viable targets to support a real GTM motion?
- ? Are there outliers that should be treated separately rather than allowed to define the lane?

Fifth, the work introduced profile-adjusted ordering logic. Instead of relying only on profile theory or target averages, the final ordering combined:

- ? theoretical profile score
- ? representative target mean
- ? target density
- ? outlier dependency robustness
- ? confidence score

This produced a more disciplined result than TAM-first reasoning or intuition alone.

Sixth, the methodology was interpreted through sequence value, not raw arithmetic alone. This mattered because some profiles are strategically more important than their direct score suggests. The clearest example is employer-connected mission and workforce intermediaries. They are not the strongest pure proof environment, but they are the strongest bridge lane from initial proof into a broader workforce-system story.

Finally, the work layered in commercial analysis, including rough likely ACV, TAM, SAM, SOM, and decision-maker structure by buyer type. That made it possible to compare not just strategic fit, but also the commercial character of each lane.

The result is not a perfect market model. It is a structured GTM sequencing model designed to answer one practical question: where should the Frontier Model SLM start if the objective is to maximize proof quality, model improvement, and long-run market expansion?

III. BUYER TYPES, REPRESENTATIVE TARGET ORGANIZATIONS, AND DECISION-MAKER PROFILE

1. Closed-Loop Talent Transformation and Placement Intermediaries

Why this lane matters

Best starting proof environment. Strongest combination of planning pain, loop closure, outcomes visibility, and repeatability.

Representative target organizations

- ? Revature
- ? SkillStorm
- ? Dev10
- ? Wiley Edge
- ? Smoothstack
- ? FDM Group
- ? Multiverse
- ? LaunchCode
- ? Apprenti
- ? mthree
- ? Catalyte
- ? TEKsystems

Likely economic buyers

- ? CEO
- ? COO
- ? CRO
- ? GM of enterprise / workforce solutions

Likely internal champions

- ? head of strategy
- ? head of talent transformation
- ? product or platform lead for workforce intelligence, matching, or training operations

Rough commercial profile

- ? likely ACV: \$250K-\$750K
- ? rough TAM: \$50M-\$105M

2. Employer-Connected Mission and Workforce Intermediaries

Why this lane matters

Best bridge market after proof. Broadens the story into employer legitimacy, mobility, and pathway-system relevance.

Representative target organizations

- ? Year Up / YUPRO
- ? Per Scholas
- ? NPower
- ? Genesys Works
- ? Merit America
- ? Opportunity@Work
- ? STRIVE
- ? Workforce Opportunity Services (WOS)
- ? Braven
- ? SkillUp Coalition

Likely economic buyers

- ? CEO
- ? COO
- ? EVP of employer solutions
- ? head of talent networks or placement

Likely internal champions

- ? head of employer partnerships
- ? head of program strategy
- ? chief innovation or impact officer
- ? analytics or outcomes lead

Rough commercial profile

- ? likely ACV: \$200K-\$500K
- ? rough TAM: \$18M-\$45M

3. Community College Apprenticeship and Pathway Programs

Why this lane matters

Strongest higher-ed-adjacent expansion lane. Preserves occupational specificity, employer linkage, and repeatability.

Representative target organizations

- ? Apprenticeship Carolina
- ? Trident Technical College
- ? Ivy Tech Community College
- ? Wake Technical Community College
- ? Northern Virginia Community College
- ? Miami Dade College
- ? WSU Tech
- ? Dallas College
- ? Maricopa Community Colleges
- ? Columbus State Community College

Likely economic buyers

- ? VP of workforce development
- ? dean of workforce / continuing education
- ? executive director of apprenticeship or employer pathways
- ? system chancellor or provost in some cases

Likely internal champions

- ? workforce innovation lead
- ? employer partnerships lead
- ? institutional research or outcomes lead
- ? regional workforce dean

Rough commercial profile

- ? likely ACV: \$150K-\$350K
- ? rough TAM: \$35M-\$75M

4. Large Employers with Strategic Workforce Planning Pain

Why this lane matters

Strongest direct-scale commercial market, but better after proof than before it.

Representative target organizations

- ? Accenture
- ? Deloitte
- ? Cognizant
- ? Infosys
- ? JPMorgan Chase
- ? Bank of America
- ? Capital One
- ? IBM
- ? Microsoft
- ? Salesforce
- ? Amazon
- ? Walmart
- ? Randstad

Likely economic buyers

- ? CHRO
- ? Chief Learning Officer
- ? COO
- ? Chief Strategy Officer
- ? business unit president for workforce-intensive divisions

Likely internal champions

- ? VP of workforce planning
- ? head of talent intelligence
- ? head of internal mobility or skills strategy

- ? AI transformation lead
- ? people analytics lead

Rough commercial profile
 ? likely ACV: \$500K-\$1.5M+
 ? rough TAM: \$750M-\$2B

5. Higher-Ed Institutions with Co-op and Externship Outcome Closure

Why this lane matters

High-quality but narrower institutional lane. Useful selectively, but more outlier-dependent.

Representative target organizations

- ? Northeastern University
- ? Drexel University
- ? University of Cincinnati
- ? Wentworth Institute of Technology
- ? Kettering University
- ? Purdue Polytechnic
- ? Georgia Tech
- ? Rochester Institute of Technology
- ? Stevens Institute of Technology
- ? Worcester Polytechnic Institute

Likely economic buyers

- ? provost
- ? president in select cases
- ? dean of career-integrated learning
- ? VP for strategy, innovation, or workforce initiatives

Likely internal champions

- ? career services leader
- ? experiential learning leader
- ? institutional research leader
- ? dean of professional or applied programs

Rough commercial profile
 ? likely ACV: \$200K-\$500K
 ? rough TAM: \$19M-\$60M

6. State Workforce Agencies and Systems

Why this lane matters

Long-run infrastructure market. Strong signaling and system value, but slower and heavier than other lanes.

Representative target organizations

- ? Virginia workforce system
- ? South Carolina workforce / apprenticeship system
- ? North Carolina workforce and community college ecosystem
- ? Indiana workforce ecosystem
- ? Colorado talent development ecosystem
- ? Tennessee workforce and higher-ed alignment ecosystem
- ? Texas Workforce Commission ecosystem
- ? California workforce system
- ? Ohio workforce ecosystem
- ? Michigan workforce system

Likely economic buyers

- ? commissioner or secretary of labor / workforce
- ? chief workforce officer
- ? executive leader of state workforce or talent office
- ? governor's office or economic development leadership in some cases

Likely internal champions

? head of workforce strategy

? labor-market intelligence lead

? apprenticeship or community college alignment lead

? deputy commissioner for planning or innovation

Rough commercial profile

? likely ACV: \$500K-\$1.5M+

? rough TAM: \$38M-\$60M

CLOSING READ

The starting-market decision should not be driven by which lane is largest, most prestigious, or most intuitively exciting. It should be driven by which lane best enables proof, learning, credibility, and compounding expansion.

On that basis, the Frontier Model SLM should begin with closed-loop intermediaries, bridge through employer-connected workforce intermediaries, expand through community college pathway systems, then scale into large employers and later infrastructure buyers.

That is the most defensible order given the current evidence.